

This Patient Group Direction (PGD) is intended only for registered healthcare professionals who have been named and authorised by their organisation to practice under it.

Patient Group Direction

for the administration of Varenicline 0.5mg and 1mg tablets (Champix) for the treatment of Smoking Cessation

Summary of NICE / NICE CKS Guidelines for Smoking Cessation

Overview

- Smoking is the leading preventable cause of death
- Nicotine dependence is a chronic relapsing condition
- Pharmacotherapy (varenicline, NRT, bupropion) doubles quit rates compared to placebo

Assessment

- Fagerström score to assess nicotine dependence
- Assess readiness to quit and motivation
- Set a quit date (typically 1-2 weeks from assessment)
- Review previous quit attempts and reasons for relapse
- Screen for contraindications and red flags

Management

- Varenicline is first-line pharmacotherapy for smoking cessation
- Start 1-2 weeks before quit date to achieve steady state
- Combine with structured behavioural support for optimal outcomes
- Follow-up at 2 weeks, 4 weeks, then monthly during treatment

Red Flags

- **Psychiatric history:** Depression, anxiety disorder, psychosis, bipolar disorder - varenicline can exacerbate mood symptoms
- **Suicidal ideation:** Assess risk; varenicline is associated with neuropsychiatric effects
- **Cardiovascular disease:** Recent MI (within 4 weeks), unstable angina, severe arrhythmias - assess benefit vs risk

Patient Group Direction

for the supply/administration of

Varenicline 0.5mg and 1mg tablets (Champix)

for the treatment of

Smoking Cessation

Healthcare professionals covered and training

	Healthcare professionals allowed to work under this PGD and requirements
Qualifications and Registration	• Pharmacist registered and practicing with the GPhC • Pharmacy technician registered and practicing with the GPhC
Training and assessment	Pharmacists and Pharmacy Technicians must have completed training relevant to this condition to use this PGD. This training will be documented and overseen by the Get Real Health team. • All users must be familiar with the SPC for the products as well as BNF advice and any applicable national guidelines • All users must previously have used PGDs to supply medication • Must work in compliance with the SOPs of their own employer • All users must have appropriate indemnity in place to cover this service
Further training and responsibilities	• All users must be up to date with CPD requirements and appraisal • All users must be up to date with MHRA and safety alerts with regards to medical products • All users must understand the concepts of capacity and consent and be aware of the Mental Capacity Act 2005.

PGD Indication	Smoking cessation in adults aged 18 years and over who have set a quit date
Inclusion criteria	Age 18 years and over Motivated to quit smoking Set a quit date within the next 1-2 weeks Capacity and willingness to provide informed consent
Exclusion criteria	Known hypersensitivity to varenicline or excipients Pregnancy or breastfeeding End-stage renal disease (eGFR <30 ml/min/1.73m²) Age under 18 years
Cautions	Psychiatric history: depression, anxiety disorder, psychosis, or bipolar disorder (varenicline can exacerbate mood symptoms; monitor closely) History of suicidal ideation or self-harm (monitor mental health throughout treatment) Cardiovascular disease: recent MI (within 4 weeks), unstable angina, or severe cardiac arrhythmias (assess benefit vs risk)

	Seizure disorders (varenicline may lower seizure threshold; rare but serious) Renal impairment: eGFR 30-50 ml/min/1.73m² - maximum dose 1mg twice daily; eGFR <30 - maximum dose 0.5mg twice daily Driving or operating heavy machinery (varenicline may cause dizziness, somnolence, or impaired concentration)
Actions if patient is excluded or declines treatment	Advise on alternative treatment options and how these can be accessed. Document any advice given and the decision reached. Inform or refer to the GP as appropriate.

Details of the medicine

Name, form and strength of medicine	Varenicline 0.5mg and 1mg tablets (Champix)
Legal category	POM
Storage	Below 30°C. Protect from light. Keep in original packaging.
Route/method of administration	Oral, swallowed whole with water. May be taken with or without food.
Dose and frequency	Days 1-3: 0.5mg once daily Days 4-7: 0.5mg twice daily (morning and evening) Day 8 to end of treatment: 1mg twice daily (morning and evening) Quit date should be on day 8-14 of treatment (when 1mg twice daily is established) Standard course: 12 weeks. Consider additional 12 weeks (total 24 weeks) for sustained abstinence to reduce relapse risk
Quantity to be administered and/or supplied	Starter pack (first 4 weeks) then up to 56 tablets (4-week supply at full dose of 1mg twice daily)
Maximum or minimum treatment period	12 weeks; may extend to 24 weeks total. Review at 2 weeks, 4 weeks, then monthly.
Adverse effects	Very common ($\geq 1/10$): Nausea (dose-related, usually transient and improves with time; may take with food if needed); insomnia; abnormal dreams Common ($\geq 1/100$, $< 1/10$): Headache; somnolence; dizziness; dry mouth; constipation; flatulence; vomiting; dyspepsia; fatigue Uncommon ($\geq 1/1000$, $< 1/100$): Mood changes; sleep disturbance; appetite changes Rare (serious): Depression; suicidal ideation (monitor closely throughout treatment); cardiovascular events (MI, stroke); seizures; angioedema

Yellow card reporting	Report suspected adverse effects via https://yellowcard.mhra.gov.uk and inform the GP as appropriate.
Records to be kept	Record the following information: • that valid informed consent was given • name of individual, address, date of birth and GP • name of healthcare practitioner • name and brand of medication • date of supply dose, form and route quantity supplied • advice given, including advice given if excluded or declines treatment • details of any adverse drug reactions and actions taken supplied via PGD Records should be signed and dated. All records should be clear, legible and contemporaneous. Electronic records can be made. A record of all individuals receiving treatment under this PGD should also be kept for audit purposes as follows: • Adults aged 18 years and over - keep records for 8 years • Children aged under 18 years - keep records until the 25th birthday (if the patient was 17 years when treatment was finished, keep records until the 26th birthday)

Patient information

Written information to be given to patient or carer	Supply the Patient Information Leaflet (PIL) provided with Champix tablets. Ensure patient understands the dosing schedule and importance of adherence.
Follow-up advice to be given to patient or carer	Set your quit date on day 8-14 of treatment (when you start taking 1mg twice daily) Nausea is common initially but usually settles; taking the tablet with food may help Report any mood changes, depression, anxiety, or suicidal thoughts immediately to your healthcare provider or GP Contact your GP or healthcare provider if you experience chest pain, shortness of breath, or severe headaches Continue taking varenicline even if you have a slip-up (single cigarette); discuss with your pharmacist or GP Avoid driving or operating machinery if you experience dizziness or somnolence Combine varenicline with behavioural support (smoking cessation counselling, quitlines) for best results Attend follow-up appointments at 2 weeks, 4 weeks, and monthly to monitor progress and side effects

	If you become pregnant, inform your GP or healthcare provider immediately Do not stop taking varenicline suddenly; discuss any changes with your GP
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Key references

- NICE Medicines Practice Guideline 2 (MPG2): Patient Group Directions. Published March 2017
<https://www.nice.org.uk/guidance/mg2>
- NICE MPG2 Patient group directions: competency framework for health professionals using patient group directions. Updated March 2017
<https://www.nice.org.uk/guidance/mpg2/resources>
- NICE CKS Guidance: Smoking Cessation
- British National Formulary (BNF) Key information on the selection, prescribing, dispensing and administration of medicines

Agreement to practise by the Registered Healthcare Professional

By signing this PGD you are confirming that you agree to its contents and that you will work within it. PGDs do not remove inherent professional obligations or accountability. It is the responsibility of each healthcare professional to practise only within the bounds of their own competence and professional code of conduct.

Name and address of pharmacy premises / clinic premises to which this PGD relates			
Name of healthcare professional	Job title	Registration number	Signature
Valid from date	Expiry date		
1/11/25	31/10/26		

PGD adoption and authorisation by the employer/clinical lead

The employer has ensured that the person using this PGD, has the knowledge and skills to safely provide the service which will encompass the supply or administration of a medication or medicine.

This section must be signed by the superintendent or clinical lead responsible for this service.

Name of superintendent / clinical lead	Job title & name of organisation	Signature	Date
Name of professional group signatory	Job title & name of organisation	Signature	Date

Signed on behalf of Get Real Health

Name	Qualification	Signature	Date
Nitin Shori	Medical Doctor GMC: 6047293		2/11/25
Chris Pilkington	Pharmacist GPhC: 2046322		2/11/25

Change history

Version number	Change details	Date
001	Development & issue of new PGD	1st November 2025